

outside investor, created the Thiel Fellowship to reward talented individuals who leave the traditional path of college and pursue immediate ways to make an impact in the world. Winners might conduct scientific research, create a startup, or find other ways to improve society and the world. Thiel Fellowship's carefully chosen visionaries receive \$100,000 over the course of two years, and the award has been considered more competitive than gaining acceptance to the world's best universities. In June 2014, Buterin received the Thiel Fellowship<sup>14</sup> as a 20-year-old dropping out of the University of Waterloo to pursue his interest in Ethereum on a full-time basis.

While Buterin may go down as one of Thiel's greatest investments, Thiel wasn't alone in recognizing the potential of Ethereum. In 2014, Buterin was given the World Technology Award in Information Technology Software,<sup>15</sup> alongside influential names such as Elon Musk in the Energy category and Walter Isaacson in Media & Journalism.

While the Thiel Fellowship was an indication of what was to come for Buterin, \$100,000 wasn't enough to sustain his team. To that end, from July 23, 2014, to September 2, 2014, they staged a 42-day presale of ether, the cryptocommodity underlying the Ethereum network.<sup>16</sup>

Ether was sold at a range of 1,337 to 2,000 ether per bitcoin, with 2,000 ether per bitcoin on offer for the first two weeks of the presale and then declining linearly toward 1,337 ether per bitcoin in the latter half of the sale, creating momentum by incentivizing people to buy in at the beginning.